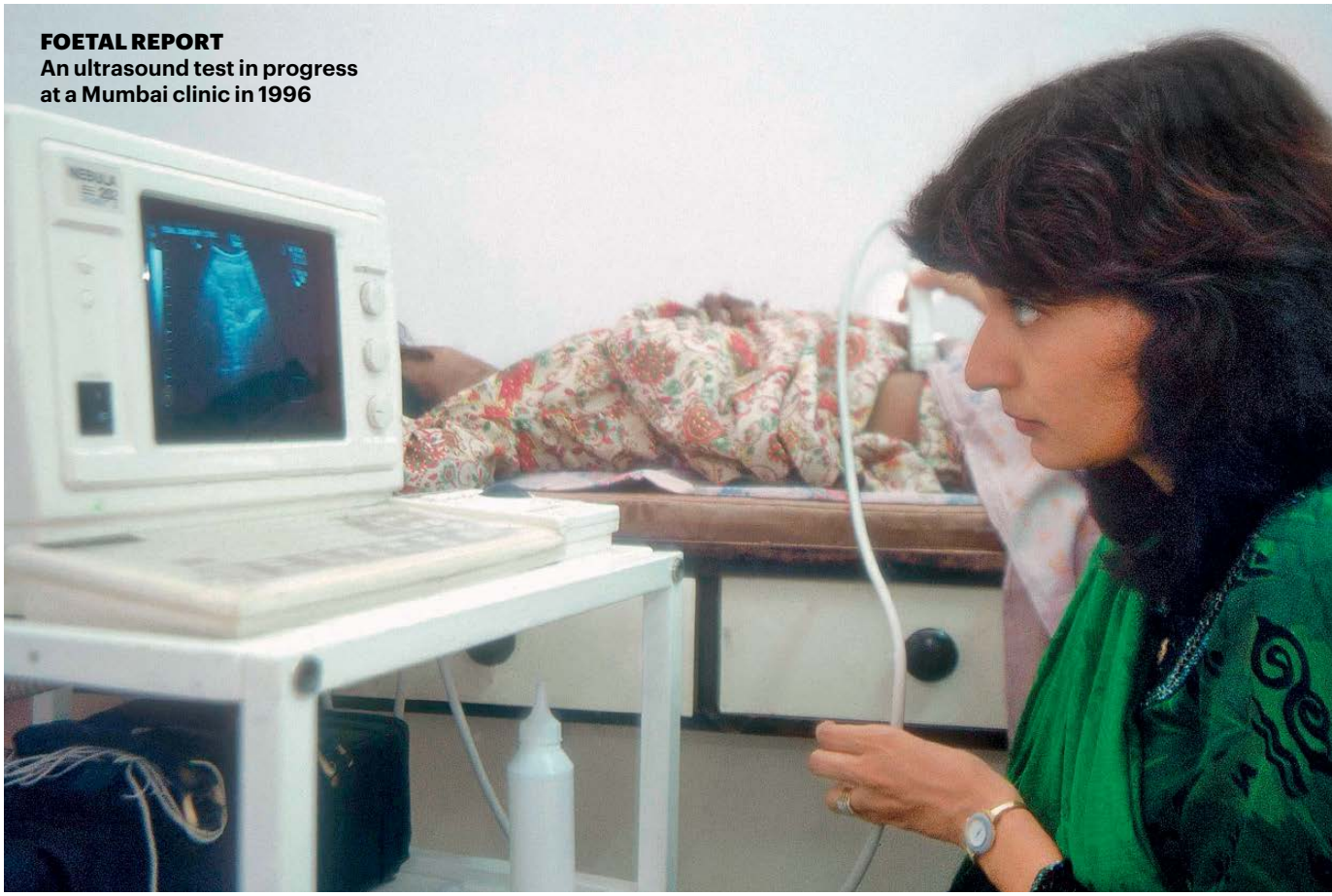


FOETAL REPORT
An ultrasound test in progress at a Mumbai clinic in 1996

FAWZAN HUSAIN

49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
SOCIETY & TRENDS

PRE-NATAL SEX DETERMINATION BAN, 1994

SAVING THE UNBORN DAUGHTER

By banning pre-natal sex determination, India took the first step towards preventing the murder of a girl child in the womb. From that has flowed other latter-day battles–like the one for her right to education

BY SONALI ACHARJEE

To be killed before being born. What greater violation of human right can there be? Yet female foeticide, the inhuman act of getting rid of a girl child, has survived well into the 21st century, if India's sex ratio at birth (SRB) is anything to go by. It stood at 108.1 boys per 100 girls in 2020 when the natural SRB is 105. India last had that SRB before the 1970s.

Saving the girl child has therefore been a long-standing priority in the country. The PNDT or Prenatal Diagnostic Techniques (Regulation and Prevention of Misuse) Act, 1994, was one of the first steps towards it. It prohibited genetic counselling centres, labs and clinics from undertaking activities related to pre-natal testing, banned the sale of ultrasound machines to such establish-

DID YOU KNOW?

Under the Act, even the sale, distribution, supply or renting of any equipment to detect the sex of a foetus is illegal